

Speak, talk, say, and tell

Learner workbook

Choose a verb that fits the message and listener.

Understand the distinction

Say focuses on the words or message: She said hello; she said that she was busy. Tell commonly names the listener directly: She told me that she was busy. Use say something to someone, not say someone something.

Speak and talk often overlap for conversation. Speak is common with languages: speak Arabic. Talk about introduces a topic. Learn common exceptions as phrases: tell a story, tell the truth, speak to someone, talk to or with someone.

Compare the patterns

MESSAGE

She said the meeting was canceled.

The focus is the message.

LISTENER

She told me the meeting was canceled.

Me identifies the listener.

TOPIC

We talked about the schedule.

About introduces the topic.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Choose the correction: She said me the answer.

- A. She said me to the answer.
- B. She told to me the answer.
- C. She told me the answer.

2. Complete: Do you ___ Korean?

- A. speak
- B. say
- C. tell

3. Does tell always need a listener?

- A. No. Tell can never name a listener.
- B. Yes. Every use must name a listener.
- C. No. Common phrases include tell a story and tell the truth.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Your colleague gave you a message about a new room. Which report is grammatical and names the recipient?

- A. My colleague said me that the room had changed.
- B. My colleague told to me that the room had changed.
- C. My colleague told me that the room had changed.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. C. She told me the answer.

Alternatively: She said the answer to me.

2. A. speak

Speak is the usual verb for language ability.

3. C. No. Common phrases include tell a story and tell the truth.

Learn the whole phrase with its meaning.

4. C. My colleague told me that the room had changed.

Told me names the recipient and introduces the reported message.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-36.html